



into a whole new segment of sport.

Building the base

No ecosystem can grow without facilities. The Sportlight report estimates India's sports infrastructure market at USD 2.7 billion, covering stadiums, academies, training centres and turf facilities. States such as Odisha, Gujarat and Tamil Nadu have led the way with multi-sport hubs and High-Performance centres. With India set to host the Commonwealth Games in 2030, investment in infrastructure will grow further, and this will be consolidated if India wins the mandate for the Olympics in 2036. Private investment is also accelerating through schools, universities and real-estate developments. Public-private partnerships are giving rise to new models of sports infrastructure, while Khelo India continues to drive grassroots participation.

Grassroots to greatness

India's talent pipeline is maturing. More than 1,000 Khelo India Centres and over 100 SAI facilities train around 20,000 athletes every year. Sports education, a USD 300-million sector, is expanding through new universities in Tamil Nadu, Odisha and Bihar, producing qualified

professionals in coaching, management and sports science.

The athlete economy, valued at USD 800 million, reflects how Indian sportspersons are becoming brands in their own right. From endorsement deals to entrepreneurial ventures, athletes are now economic players, not just competitors.

Private capital steps in

Sport is increasingly attracting private equity and venture capital. In FY25 alone, over USD 180 million was invested in sports technology, analytics and league ventures. Investors are drawn to sectors with recurring digital revenues such as fantasy gaming, data analytics, fan engagement and women's sport.

Corporates are equally active. CSR spending reached Rs. 590 crore in 2024. The shift from short-term branding to long-term partnerships marks a maturing market where brands seek purpose and community impact alongside visibility.

Policy push and governance reform

Government involvement remains pivotal. Combined spending by Central and State departments stands at around USD 1.7 billion.

Odisha continues to be a national

Rewriting the rule book: The rise of new leagues like Pro Panja, digital broadcasting and private investment has redefined the way sport is played, consumed and monetised in India.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

model with Rs. 4,124 crore committed to sports infrastructure, followed by Bihar (Rs. 568 crore) and Gujarat (Rs. 606 crore). Reforms are also reshaping the institutional landscape. The establishment of a National Sports Board and Sports Tribunal (2025) aims to strengthen governance, transparency and athlete rights across more than 60 National Sports Federations.

Global capability centres, events and tourism

Sport in India is spilling out of arenas and into allied industries. The Global Capability Centres (GCCs) segment, worth about USD 200 million, is positioning India as a global hub for sports analytics, broadcast operations and creative services.

Meanwhile, sports events and tourism, together valued at over USD 4 billion, are driving local economies through marathons, adventure races and international tournaments. Sport has become both a lifestyle and a livelihood, influencing travel, retail and entertainment.

Road ahead

Sportlight 2025 identifies several priorities for the decade ahead: expanding infrastructure beyond metros, professionalising sports education, improving governance consistency and diversifying investment beyond cricket.

If these priorities are met, India could unlock the full potential of a USD 40-billion sports economy by 2030 — creating jobs, nurturing inclusion and strengthening its global sporting identity.

What makes this transformation remarkable is not just the scale of investment but the shift in mindset. Sport in India is no longer a side act; it's an industry that is dynamic, data-driven and determined to deliver both passion and performance.

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